

Introduction

When you find out that you are pregnant, you may feel excited and a little fearful of the unknown. Rest assured that most women have straightforward pregnancies, have uncomplicated births, and deliver a healthy baby. This book provides clear, unbiased, and, where possible, evidence-based advice to support you through the journey. The information has been written by a variety of health-care professionals, all of whom have contributed to the safe care of women in pregnancy and during birth, as well as taking care of newborn infants over many years. I thank them for their contributions.

This book gives guidance when planning a pregnancy and discusses the normal symptoms that many, if not all, women experience. Straightforward advice is given on the many practical aspects of pregnancy, such as how to choose a place of birth and issues to consider to ensure the safety of mother and baby.

Some women, in particular circumstances, may need additional information and knowledge. In this new edition, the existing text has been supplemented by descriptions of the new tests available in pregnancy. There is also information on the additional monitoring and interventions that are now performed if there are any complications that may impact on the health of the mother or her unborn baby.

Over 30 percent of women now give birth either by a planned or an emergency Cesarean section, so there is updated information on why a woman might need a Cesarean, what the process involves, a description of any complications, and a more detailed section on the recovery. Induction of labor rates continue to increase, so more information has been provided on why a woman might need to be induced and a description of the steps involved.

Also in this new edition, we have introduced an emphasis on the monitoring of fetal movements and screening for poor growth in the unborn baby, which can help to reduce the risk of stillbirth. There is also additional guidance provided on the situations in which women should seek urgent help.

I hope this book helps you to navigate one of the most exciting journeys that any woman can undertake.

A handwritten signature in black ink that reads "Maggie Blott". The script is cursive and fluid, with the first letters of "Maggie" and "Blott" being capitalized and prominent.

Dr. Maggie Blott